

Arashk Afshar

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RESEARCH FIELDS

Public Economics, Political Economy, Microeconomic Theory

EDUCATION

Rutgers University, New Brunswick, NJ

Ph.D., Economics (expected May 2027)

M.A., Economics, 2023

Advisor and Dissertation Committee Chair: Oriol Carbonell-Nicolau

University of Washington Tacoma, Tacoma, WA

B.A., Business Administration (Finance), *Summa Cum Laude*, 2019

B.S., Mathematics, *Magna Cum Laude*, 2019

Green River College, Auburn, WA

A.A., Business, *Highest Honors*, 2016

JOB MARKET PAPER

Saving as a Luxury Good: Why Progressive Taxation Cannot Guarantee Falling Inequality

When the rich save a larger share of their wealth, no progressive tax guarantees that inequality falls over time. We show the classical characterizations hold within a period but not across periods, and that what governs the trajectory is a schedule's residual progression, a parameter every enacted and proposed wealth tax leaves untouched.

WORKING PAPERS

The Myth of the Informed Voter

Even fully informed voters can be decided by which issues a campaign makes salient rather than by what they know: money shapes elections through attention, not information. A binding spending cap forces competition across many issues at once, though whether it seats the broadly representative candidate depends on the structure of the electorate.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Saving as Instrument and Status: Progressive Taxation in a Dynamic Economy

A dynamic extension with forward-looking agents, testing whether the non-convergence result survives without myopia. It does not. Anticipating the returns to accumulation, the wealthy save more aggressively still, and containing the divergence requires marginal-rate progressivity, a stricter standard than average-rate.

PRESENTATIONS

- *Saving as a Luxury Good*. Microeconomic Theory Workshop, Rutgers University, October 2026 (scheduled).
- *The Myth of the Informed Voter*. Microeconomic Theory Workshop, Rutgers University, 2024.

TEACHING

Fourteen sections as instructor of record at Rutgers across five courses, twelve of them upper-level economics (300/400), with regular-semester enrollments up to seventy-five. Designed each of the three electives around a semester-long policy analysis paper, presented at both proposal and final stages.

- **Econ 440: Economics of Income Inequality and Discrimination.** Spring 2025, Spring 2026, Spring 2027 (scheduled). Designed the course and syllabus from a dormant catalog listing.
- **Econ 438: Education Economics.** Fall 2026. Designed the syllabus.
- **Econ 402: Labor Economics.** Summer 2024, Summer 2025, Summer 2026. Designed the syllabus.
- **Econ 320: Intermediate Microeconomic Analysis.** Summer 2023 (2 sections), Fall 2025 (2 sections), Spring 2026. Taught from a fully calculus-based treatment.
- **College Writing 101**, Department of English. Fall 2024 (2 sections).

Teaching Service: **Panelist and Breakout Facilitator**, New Teaching Assistant Orientation, Institute for Teaching, Innovation, and Inclusive Pedagogy (TIIP), Rutgers University, August 2025. Shared teaching experience and led a breakout session for more than 100 incoming teaching assistants.

Teaching Fields: Public Economics and Taxation; Microeconomic Theory and Game Theory; Industrial Organization; Labor Economics; Economics of Education

TEACHING AWARD

Sidney I. Simon Award, 2024. For outstanding teaching by a graduate student, Department of Economics, Rutgers University.

OTHER ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

- Teaching Assistant, Rutgers University, 2021–2024
- Research Assistant, University of Washington Tacoma, 2018–2019

HONORS AND FELLOWSHIPS

- Nominated, President's Medal, University of Washington Tacoma, 2019
- Interdisciplinary Award, for outstanding treatment of mathematics within other areas of study, University of Washington Tacoma, 2019
- *Pi Mu Epsilon* (mathematics, 2017) and *Beta Gamma Sigma* (business, 2016) honor societies
- Multiple merit scholarships, University of Washington Tacoma and Green River College

COMMUNITY SERVICE

- Volunteer Tax Preparer, United Way of King County
- Volunteer Tutor, University of Washington Tacoma and Green River College

SOFTWARE AND LANGUAGES

Python, R, Stata, MATLAB, $\text{\LaTeX}$ · English (fluent); Farsi (native)

REFERENCES

Oriol Carbonell-Nicolau (Advisor and Committee Chair)

Professor of Economics, Rutgers University · carbonell-nicolau@rutgers.edu

Richard P. McLean (Committee member)

Distinguished Professor of Economics, Rutgers University · rpmclean@economics.rutgers.edu

Andrew Mackenzie (Committee member)

Assistant Professor of Economics, Rutgers University · andrew.k.mackenzie@rutgers.edu